

PRIVATE AIRCRAFT

INITIALLY ALL AIRCRAFT WERE private aircraft, made for sportsmen and women or for the amusement of wealthy enthusiasts. The growth of military and then commercial aviation led to the evolution by the 1930s of a distinctive category of light airplane aimed at leisure fliers or small-scale practical uses such as crop dusting or passenger transportation in remote areas. To succeed, these aircraft had to be cheap and sturdy, and relatively easy to fly. Around the same time, home-assembly aircraft kits began to gain a popularity they would never entirely lose. The use of light aircraft expanded massively after World War II, with the Piper, Beech, and Cessna companies as the main beneficiaries. The introduction of the private jet in the 1960s created a new category of aircraft for corporations and the superrich, which rivaled commercial airliners in sophistication and performance. Meanwhile the development of ultralights and kit-built aircraft brought a new form of relatively inexpensive leisure flying.



LEARJET LUXURY

The top-of-the-range Learjet 60 series combined the Longhorn wings with the fuselage and engine of the 35 series to give it the fastest speed and longest range of all the Learjet planes. See pages 420–21.

Beech Bonanza D35

The Bonanza, with its distinctive V-tail, all-metal construction and retractable undercarriage, set a new standard for light aircraft. However, nobody could have forecast that over 10,000 would be built since its debut in 1945 or that production would continue until 1982.

ENGINE 205hp Continental E-185 flat 6 piston engine	
WINGSPAN 32ft 10in (10m)	LENGTH 25ft 2in (7.7m)
CRUISING SPEED 175mph (281kph)	
PASSENGERS 3	CREW 1



Cessna 172R Skyhawk

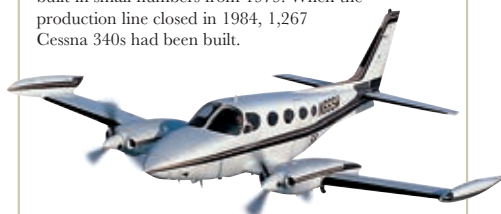


A tricycle undercarriage version of the popular Cessna 170, the first four-seat Cessna 172 flew in November 1955. The type was immediately successful, and this popularity has continued to the present day with over 42,000 sold, making the Cessna 172 the world's most successful light aircraft.

ENGINE 160hp Textron Lycoming 10-360 flat 4 piston engine	
WINGSPAN 36ft 1in (11m)	LENGTH 27ft 2in (8.3m)
CRUISING SPEED 140mph (226kph)	
PASSENGERS 3	CREW 1

Cessna 340

When the Cessna 340 was first offered for sale in 1971, it fit in between the long established 4–6 seat Cessna 310 and the 6–8 seat Cessna 414/421. With a pressurized cabin and an integral airstair door, the aircraft was aimed at the business market. A lighter, unpressurized version, the Cessna 335, was also built in small numbers from 1979. When the production line closed in 1984, 1,267 Cessna 340s had been built.



ENGINE 2 x 310hp Continental TS10-520 Turbocharged flat 6 piston	
WINGSPAN 38ft 1in (11.6m)	LENGTH 34ft 4in (10.5m)
CRUISING SPEED 264mph (425kph)	
PASSENGERS 5	CREW 1

Dassault Mystère Falcon 900C

Derived from the earlier tri-jet Falcon 50 to provide greater range, the Falcon 900 was announced at the June 1983 Paris Air Salon with the first prototype flying in September 1984. The second prototype demonstrated its intercontinental range by flying nonstop from Paris to Little Rock, Arkansas. Deliveries to customers started in December 1986 with over 180 orders. The current standard model is the Falcon 900C, but an even longer-range version, the 900EX, was launched in October 1994.

ENGINE 3 x 4,750lbs Honeywell TFE731-5BR-1C turbofan	
WINGSPAN 63ft 5in (19.3m)	LENGTH 66ft 4in (20.2m)
CRUISING SPEED 551mph (887kph)	
PASSENGERS 8–15	CREW 2



Eipper Quicksilver E (Ultralight)

Eipper Formance manufactured the Quicksilver hang-glider, designed in 1972 by Bob Lovejoy, and some 2,000 had been sold when production ended in 1981. When equipped with an engine, the aircraft became one of the first foot-launched ultralights (microlights).



ENGINE 46hp Rotax 503 piston engine	
WINGSPAN 32ft (9.8m)	LENGTH 18ft 1in (5.5m)
CRUISING SPEED 41mph (66kph)	
PASSENGERS None	CREW 1

Europa XS



In the early 1990s, Ivan Shaw had a dream. He conceived an airplane – the Europa – which could be built and kept at home, easily transported to the nearest airfield, filled up at a gas station along the way, and assembled in under five minutes, before carrying two people for extended touring.

ENGINE 80hp Rotax 912S	
WINGSPAN 27ft 2in (8.3m)	LENGTH 19ft 2in (5.8m)
CRUISING SPEED 161mph (259kph)	
PASSENGERS 1	CREW 1